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How to win a battle against terrorism and lose the war of ideas. Children shoot soldiers at point-blank range. Women plant bombs in cafes. Soon the entire Arab population builds to a mad fervor.

Sound familiar?

Poster for screening at
the Pentagon, 2003

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equal regret, as the same mournful music is played over the massacred French civilians as the dead Algerians after military raids. It asks the question: what matters more in warfare, winning or keeping your soul in the process? And it asks the same question of both sides.

The role of the media

The Battle of Algiers poses several questions about the role of the media in modern warfare. Both sides seem to understand that just as important as winning the physical battles is winning the hearts and minds of the media and thus the world. After a series of violent and terrorist acts, the FLN

decides that their next move will be a strike, in which all operatives are to lay down their weapons. The restless Ali questions this action, but is informed by his superior that to win the freedom they desire, they must make the transition in the world's eyes from terrorists to freedom fighters.

Mathieu's approach is similarly media conscious, and he confronts a room full of journalists about their "have their cake and eat it" attitude to the conflict. They disapprove of Mathieu's methods,

Colonel Mathieu (Jean Martin) is sent to Algiers to defeat the FLN in the wake of an escalation of violence from both sides.

